Analytical Study of a Home-Based Gifts Curating Company

A Proposal report for the BDM capstone Project

Submitted by

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Declaration Statement

I am working on a Project titled "**Analytical Study of a Home-Based Gifts Curating Company"**. I extend my appreciation to **B-STORIES**, for providing the necessary resources that enabled me to conduct my project.

I hereby assert that the data presented and assessed in this project report is genuine and precise to the utmost extent of my knowledge and capabilities. The data has been gathered from primary sources and carefully analyzed to assure its reliability.

Additionally, I affirm that all procedures employed for the purpose of data collection and analysis have been duly explained in this report. The outcomes and inferences derived from the data are an accurate depiction of the findings acquired through thorough analytical procedures.

I am dedicated to adhering to the principles of academic honesty and integrity, and I am receptive to any additional examination or validation of the data contained in this project report.

I understand that the execution of this project is intended for individual completion and is not to be undertaken collectively. I thus affirm that I am not engaged in any form of collaboration with other individuals, and that all the work undertaken has been solely conducted by me. In the event that plagiarism is detected in the report at any stage of the project's completion, I am fully aware and prepared to accept disciplinary measures imposed by the relevant authority.

I understand that all recommendations made in this project report are within the context of the academic project taken up towards course fulfillment in the BS Degree Program offered by IIT Madras. The institution does not endorse any of the claims or comments.

Signature of Candidate:

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Name: Muni Chandrasekar Reddy. K

Date: 10 July 2025

1 Executive Summary

B-Stories is a homegrown brand based in Chennai that emerged during the 2020 COVID-19 lockdown, founded by a passionate entrepreneur turning creativity into a business. While it has grown organically through platforms like Instagram, it faces critical operational and strategic challenges.

The brand incurs losses from rejected Cash on Delivery (COD) orders, as customers often accept deliveries only when paid in advance online—leading to wasted delivery costs and unpredictable cash flow. It also struggles with inventory management, due to irregular order volumes and uncertain demand, resulting in overstocking or missed sales. Lastly, stiff competition on Instagram has made it increasingly difficult for B-Stories to maintain visibility and drive engagement.

To address these issues, the project uses a mixed-method approach, combining qualitative insights with quantitative tools like time series analysis to forecast sales trends, track delivery outcomes, and optimize marketing efforts.

The expected outcomes include reduced delivery cost wastage, improved inventory planning, and a more effective marketing strategy, setting the foundation for sustainable and data-driven growth.

2 Organization Background

Name of the business: B-stories

Entrepreneurs name: Ruhitha K

B-Stories is a homegrown, passionate brand that was established in the year 2020. Conceived in the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic, With some leisure time available and a will to create something real, the founder set out to make a brand that combines self-care and gifting.

B-Stories offers handcrafted goods that add warmth, comfort, and a personal touch to the everyday moments. The brand offers a wide variety of handmade soaps, scented candles, and beautifully handpicked gift hampers—everything crafted with care, attention, and love of everything natural and beautiful.

Operating mostly on Instagram, B-Stories is directly connected to its customers through taking orders online and providing a smooth, personalized shopping experience. Besides being present online, the company also participates actively in fests and pop-up stalls throughout the city, providing a chance for individuals to feel the products firsthand.

3 Problem Statement

3.1.Problem Statement 1: Irregular order patterns and uncertainty in profits complicate inventory management for B-Stories, with wastage and stockouts as possible outcomes.

3.2.Problem Statement 2: Customers rejecting Cash on Delivery orders leads to wasted delivery costs for B-Stories, unlike prepaid orders which are reliably accepted.

3.3.Problem Statement 3:With increasing competition on Instagram, B-Stories is finding it hard to remain prominent and requires other types of marketing and growth strategy.

4 Background of the Problem

B-Stories experiences frequent delivery rejections when customers choose Cash on Delivery (COD), whereas orders are usually accepted when paid in advance through online payment. These COD rejections result in wasted delivery costs for the business, increasing operational expenses and reducing profitability. B-Stories experiences frequent delivery rejections when customers choose Cash on Delivery (COD), whereas orders are usually accepted when paid in advance through online payment. These COD rejections result in wasted delivery costs for the business, increasing operational expenses and reducing profitability. As a home-run business with varying and unpredictable order volumes, B-Stories is hindered by poor inventory management. In the face of irregular cash flows and uncertainty of demand, carrying excess inventory results in dead stock and wastage, while insufficient inventory means losing orders and customer confidence. There is an urgent need for analyzing and applying cost-efficient inventory planning and forecasting methods appropriate for a small-scale, demand-vulnerable business. With greater saturation and competition on Instagram, it is becoming increasingly difficult for B-Stories to remain in view and draw in new customers. The brand, even with its special identity, finds it difficult to compete with intense marketing by larger-budget brands. There is a pressing necessity to develop a differentiated digital marketing strategy, investigate other sales channels, and find alternative ways of brand growth and customer interaction beyond social media.

5 Problem Solving Approach

5a. Details about the methods used with Justification:

- Time Series Analysis (for sales and order patterns)

Justification: Time series methods (e.g., moving average, seasonality decomposition) can help identify trends, seasonal fluctuations, and forecast future sales—critical for inventory and demand planning.

- Root Cause Analysis & Pareto Charting

Justification: These are useful for identifying the most frequent reasons for COD delivery failures, helping prioritize operational fixes.

- SWOT Analysis

Justification: A SWOT analysis will enable the researcher to identify internal strengths/weaknesses (like self-financing or no stock inventory systems) and external opportunities or threats (like competition on Instagram) to establish the basis for strategy creation.

5b. Techniques for Collecting Data & Justification:

a. Historical Sales and Order Data Collection

- Method: Monthly/weekly order and sales data can be extracted from order logs, the backend of the website where sales often occur, or on the Instagram order tracking tracking sheet.
- Justification: Historical order and sales data will be collected in order to conduct time series analysis to understand demand patterns, peak seasons and return rates for all found and invented retailers.

b. Delivery outcomes (COD vs Prepaid)

- Method: If using a database, plan to log the delivery type, and if it was accepted/rejected , also the cost per delivery.
- Justification: With COD payment models, this will allow us to conduct quantitative analysis of COD failure rates, transport implications and cost impact overtime.

c. Online Customer Surveys

- Method: Using Google Forms or Instagram Poll, survey customers for feedback on their favourite payment method as well the reasoning behind rejected COD orders..
- Justification: This old-school qualitative reasoning combined with quantification of trends in consumer behaviour is about as good as it gets for market feedback and improvements.

5c. Analysis Tools & Justification:

a. Excel or Google Sheets

• Uses:

• Plot out sales/orders over time

• Forecast using moving average, in say also calculated trends alongside forecasted points of range

• Using Pivot tables for comparing pre-paid and COD

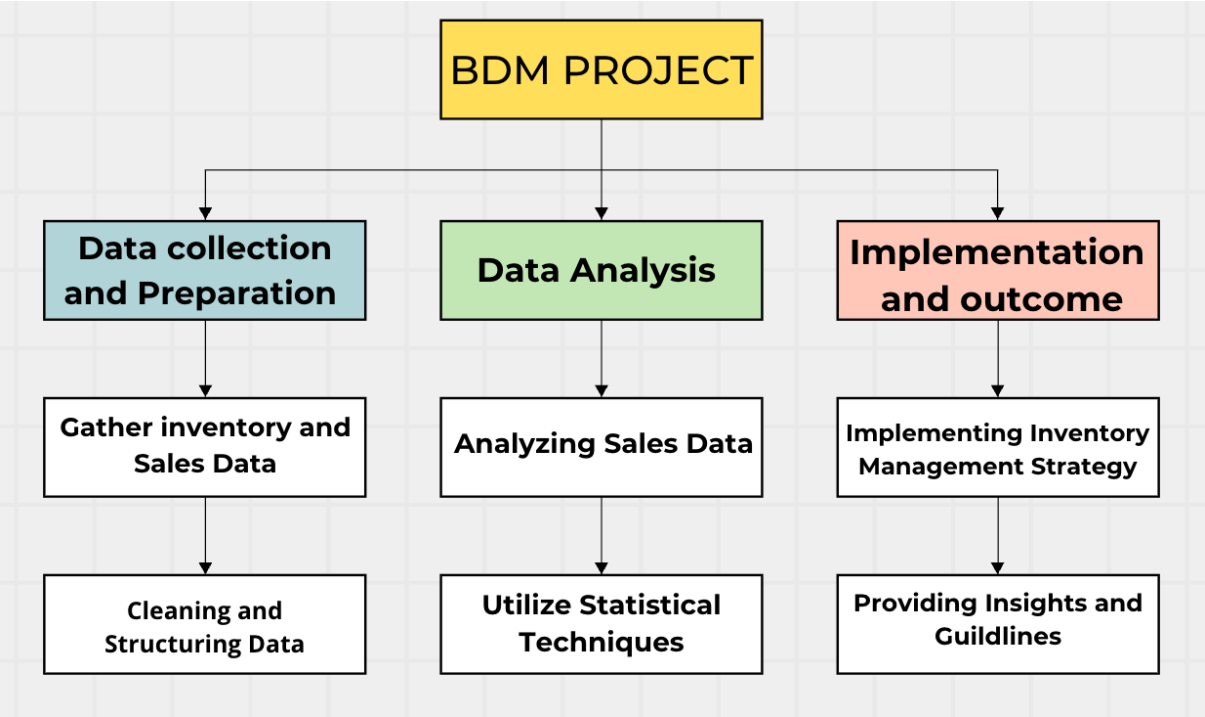
• Justification: Available, easy to use/access, and is fine for a starting point of analysis.

b. SWOT Matrix Tool (digital methods)

• Justification: Good to bring findings together into strategic actions based on Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats.

6 Expected Timeline

6.1 Work Breakdown Structure:



6.2 Gantt chart

Figure 1: Expected timeline for completion of project.

7 Expected Outcome

- To get a clear grasp on sales trends via time series analysis of sales data to help better predict demand.
- To implement a rudimentary inventory control system - reorder level, safety stock, or any other basic EOQ model.
- To better align supply with actual customer demand, which will result in significantly lower wastage and holding costs.
- To ascertain what content works the best at what time and audience engagement with action through social media analytics.
- To expand into alternative channels - e.g. WhatsApp Business, small e-commerce sites, or even pop-up collaborations.
- To improve channel reach and engagement, and therefore likely improve conversion rates by improving storytelling and digital presence.
- To determine the major reasons identified for rejection of COD orders through customer feedback and data tracking.
- To implement a new payment policy, to limit losses from failed deliveries.